

Pterosaurs Huge flying reptiles that lived during the age of the dinosaurs. The wings of pterosaurs consisted of sheets of skin stretched between the limbs.

Ray-finned fish (Actinopterygii) A major class of fish that includes about 25,000 of today's fish species and many prehistoric species. Ray-finned fish have fins consisting of skin stretched over a fan of thin bones.

Rays (Batoidea) A group of flat-bodied, cartilaginous fish related to sharks. Examples include stingrays and manta rays.

Reptile A cold-blooded animal with scaly skin that typically lives on land and reproduces by laying eggs. Lizards, snakes, turtles, crocodiles, and dinosaurs are reptiles.

Rodents A group of mostly small mammals that includes mice, rats, squirrels, and porcupines. Rodents have sharp front teeth used for gnawing nuts and seeds.

Saurischians (lizard-hipped dinosaurs) One of the two major divisions into which the dinosaur family tree is split (see also Ornithischians). All meat-eating dinosaurs were saurischians.

Sauropods Gigantic, long-necked, plant-eating, saurischian dinosaurs. The sauropods included the largest animals ever to walk on Earth.

Savanna Tropical grassland. Savannas are often dotted with trees or patches of woodland.

Scutes Bony plates with a horny covering set in the skin of certain reptiles to protect them from the teeth and claws of enemies.

Sediment Material deposited by wind, water, or ice. Sediments such as sand, silt, and mud build up on the sea floor and are eventually turned into rock (sedimentary rock).

Sedimentary rock The type of rock in which fossils are found.

Silurian The third period in the Palaeozoic Era, from 444 to 416 million years ago.

Skull The head's bony framework that protects the brain, eyes, ears, and nasal passages.

Species A type of animal or plant. Examples of species include lions, human beings, and apple trees. Individual in a species can breed with each other.

Spinosaurids A family of huge dinosaurs of the Cretaceous Period that had sail-like structures on their backs.

Stegosaurus Four-legged, plant-eating dinosaurs with two rows of tall bony plates and/or spines running down the back.

Supercontinent A prehistoric landmass containing two or more major continental plates. Examples include Gondwana and Pangaea.

Tetrapod A vertebrate with four limbs (arms, legs, or wings). All amphibians, reptiles, mammals, and birds are tetrapods. Snakes are also tetrapods because they evolved from ancestors with four limbs.

Therizinosaurs A group of bizarre-looking dinosaurs that lived in the Cretaceous Period. Therizinosaurs were tall with small heads, stumpy feet, and pot bellies.

Theropods A large branch of the dinosaur family tree made up mostly of predators. Theropods typically had sharp teeth and claws. They ranged from hen-sized creatures to the colossal *Tyrannosaurus*.

Titanosaurs Very large, four-legged, plant-eating dinosaurs. The titanosaurs were sauropods and included perhaps the largest land animals ever.

Triassic The first period in the Mesozoic Era, from 251 to 200 million years ago. Dinosaurs emerged in the Triassic Period.

Trilobites Prehistoric sea creatures with external skeletons divided lengthwise into three lobes. Variations in the shape and features of trilobite fossils are an accurate indicator of the age of the sedimentary rocks in which they are found.

Vertebrae The linked bones forming the backbone of a vertebrate animal.

Vertebrates Animals with an internal bony or cartilaginous skeleton including a skull and a backbone. Fish, amphibians, reptiles, birds, and mammals are all vertebrates.

Warm-blooded Animals that maintain a constant internal body temperature are described

as warm-blooded. Mammals and birds are warm-blooded, whereas fish and reptiles are cold-blooded.

Wingspan The distance from the tip of one wing to the tip of the other when both wings are outstretched.

